

Iceberg

Making a glacier

When snowflakes pile up and compress into tightly packed snow, a glacier is formed. Glaciers cover roughly 10 percent of the Earth's surface and store up to 75 percent of its freshwater. Glaciers move forward as ice and snow build up and then retreat backward when thawing.

Icebergs are large chunks of ice, found in both the Arctic and Antarctic regions. They are formed when pieces break away from glaciers—huge moving masses of ice. Icebergs change shape and even color. Many sea creatures use icebergs as hunting grounds.

See also

Find out about penguins living in the icy region of Antarctica (108–109).

Emperor penguins gather on icebergs looking for food.

Breaking free

At the glacier's edge, or terminus, chunks of ice break off into the water. This is called calving, and the chunks are now icebergs. They range in size from around 6.5 ft (2 m) long to huge slabs about the size of a small country.

Floating away

Icebergs are made of frozen freshwater, yet they float on salty ocean water. They typically last for three to six years. Carried along by the waves, icebergs can crash into one another or onto land.

Ice stripes Some icebergs are striped! These dark lines come from the bits of soil and sediment that the iceberg picked up when it broke away from the glacier.

Flat tops Icebergs can be all kinds of different shapes, including wedge shaped, dome shaped, or topped with spires. Those with flat, sheetlike tops and steep sides are called tabular icebergs, such as this rectangular iceberg that was found in Antarctica.

